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an example of a star trek original series where it is evident
the studio execs messed with the ending

8 July 2026

The most famous example from [Star Trek: The Original Series](#) where studio executives and producers heavily altered the ending is "The City on the Edge of Forever". While original writer Harlan Ellison won awards for his darker script, network and production executives changed the tone and final climax of the episode. [Facebook · Sci-Fi & Star ... +4](#)

In the original script by [Harlan Ellison](#), Captain Kirk hesitated to let Edith Keeler die. To ensure the timeline was fixed, it was Spock who had to push Kirk out of the way, taking the tragic burden of the choice out of the captain's hands. [↗](#)

Executives and producer Gene Roddenberry felt this approach weakened Kirk's character. They demanded rewrites so that Kirk willingly made the agonizing decision to let his love interest die to save the universe. This forced Spock to serve as the voice of reason while Kirk bore the full emotional weight of the loss. [Quora +1](#)

The resulting televised ending cemented the episode as one of the most highly regarded in television history, but it caused a bitter, decades-long feud between [Ellison](#) and the [Star Trek](#) producers. [Facebook · Sci-Fi & Star ... +2](#)

Would you like to know more about the **other conflicts** in Harlan Ellison's original script, or are you interested in other Star Trek episodes that suffered from **behind-the-scenes meddling**?

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Ask anything





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I remember seeing an episode where it was gripping and moving in a direction but in the last act, it all fell apart ... ▾

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The episode you are remembering is almost certainly "**The Alternative Factor**" (Season 1, Episode 27), which is widely considered one of the most notoriously incoherent and messy episodes in Star Trek history. [Facebook](#) · Star Trek: Ori... +2

The production behind this episode completely fell apart, resulting in an ending that drastically contradicts the opening and forces Captain Kirk to abruptly "save the day". [Galactic Journey](#)

Why the Episode "Fell Apart"

- **The Missing Lead Actor:** Actor John Drew Barrymore (Drew Barrymore's father) was cast to play the crucial dual roles of Lazarus, a man locked in a multi-dimensional war with his antimatter doppelgänger. On the morning of filming, Barrymore simply failed to show up. [Facebook](#) · Star Trek: Origin...





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The recurring inconsistencies

- **The Broken Mystery:** The opening acts tease a gripping, massive cosmic threat where reality itself "winks out" of existence. However, because the middle explanations were cut, the plot quickly turns into an repetitive, illogical loop of Lazarus screaming and falling off cliffs. 🌌 Galactic Journey +1
- **The Unearned Climax:** In the final act, the episode completely abandons its building sci-fi premises. Kirk suddenly figures out the multidimensional physics off-screen, pushes the "bad" Lazarus into a dimensional corridor, and orders the ship to blow up his spaceship. 🌌 Galactic Journey +1
- **The Mismatched Ending:** The threat is resolved through basic action instead of solving the grand, universe-threatening mystery presented in the opening act. It leaves viewers with Kirk dramatically mourning a character the audience barely understands, rendering the climax entirely unsatisfying. 🌌 Galactic Journey +1

Does this description of the **cliff-falling** and **multidimensional double** match the episode you had in mind, or did the episode you remember feature a different kind of alien threat?

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I dont think that is the one. Was there a one set in a replica of 20th century earth, with McCoy and Spock ...



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The episode you are remembering is "**A Piece of the Action**" (Season 2, Episode 17).

While it is one of the most famous and comedic episodes of *Star Trek*, you are completely right that **the ending completely falls apart** and forces Kirk to magically save the day in a way that contradicts the opening setup. [🔗](#)

Why the Ending Doesn't Match the Opening

- **The High-Stakes Opening:** The episode starts with a serious premise. The crew visits Sigma Iotia II, a planet that has based its entire society on a 1920s Chicago gangster book left behind by a previous starship. Kirk and Spock are captured, threatened with tommy guns, and caught in a brutal, escalating mob war. [🔗](#)
- **The Sudden Ending Shift:** In the final act, the story runs out of time to solve a planet-wide societal crisis. To wrap it up quickly, Kirk suddenly drops all Starfleet morals. He effortlessly hotwires the ship's phasers from orbit to stun an entire street of mobsters.
- **The Absurd Resolution:** Kirk then forces the mob bosses into a "syndicate" where Starfleet acts as the top boss, demanding a 45% cut of their profits. The serious societal threat vanishes instantly, replaced by a comedy bit where Kirk acts like a caricature of a mob boss.

The Real Behind-the-Scenes Reason





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How about Return of the archons

8 July 2026

"The Return of the Archons" (Season 1, Episode 21) is another premier example of a *Star Trek* episode where the ending completely shifts gears, leaving the gripping, terrifying setups from the opening acts entirely abandoned. thecreativelifeadventur... +4

The episode features two major narrative components that "fall apart" due to production decisions and structural rewrites.

1. The Mystery of "The Red Hour" (The Festival)





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2. Kirk "Gasslights" a Computer to Death

The opening introduces Landru as a terrifying, seemingly omnipotent, god-like dictator who controls everyone's minds. [thecreativelifeadventure... +1](#)

- **The Mismatched Ending:** Instead of a complex solution matching the grand scale of the threat, Kirk and Spock walk into a room, pull down a curtain, and discover Landru is just an old computer projection. [Fandom +2](#)
- Kirk defeats this ancient, world-controlling AI by simply arguing with it. He uses basic circular logic, telling the computer that it has harmed "the Body" it was programmed to protect. The computer instantly suffers a system failure and explodes. [YouTube · TrekLad +2](#)

The Behind-the-Scenes Reality

This story was originally written by Gene Roddenberry years earlier to be the first *Star Trek* pilot episode. When NBC rejected it, the script sat on a shelf for over two years. [Fandom](#)

When they finally resurrected it for Season 1, freelance writer Boris Sobelman had to hastily rewrite and condense Roddenberry's massive, philosophical concepts to fit a standard 50-minute television slot. Subplots were gutted—including a romance arc—and the complex societal themes were abandoned in favor of a quick, formulaic "Kirk outsmarts the machine" ending to wrap the episode up on schedule. [Fandom +1](#)

It sounds like you have a great memory for these classic **dystopian-planet** episodes! Would you like to look at "**The Apple**" or "**For the World is Hollow and I Have Touched the Sky**", which also feature Kirk destroying societal structures in the final act?

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Yes, explain For the World is Hollow and I Have Touched the Sky

8 July 2026

"For the World is Hollow and I Have Touched the Sky" (Season 3, Episode 8) features arguably the most poetic title in *Star Trek* history, but it suffers immensely from the **severe budget cuts, executive meddling, and rushed writing** that plagued the show's final season. 🌐 TrekMovie.com +3

The episode tries to balance a massive cosmic disaster with a deeply personal tragedy, only to completely fall apart in the final act with an absurdly convenient "fix-all" ending. 🗨️ Reddit

The Gripping Dual Premise

- **McCoy's Death Sentence:** In the opening scene, Dr. McCoy diagnoses





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How the Ending Completely Falls Apart

The episode builds an incredibly heavy emotional narrative. McCoy falls in love with the planet's high priestess, Natira, and decides to spend his final, dying year living out his days on the ship with her. 🏠 Fandom +2

However, because the production ran out of time and money, the writers had to completely erase all the stakes in the span of five minutes: 📺 TrekMovie.com +1

- **Kirk Outsmarts Another Computer:** Exactly like in *The Return of the Archons*, Kirk and Spock simply walk into the main computer room. They bypass the "all-powerful" Oracle with almost no effort, hack into its files, and fix the ship's guidance system to save the Federation world. 📺 TrekMovie.com +1
- **The Miracle Cure Button:** While hacking the computer, Spock magically finds a complete medical library left behind by the ship's creators. With a single glance at the screen, Spock announces that the ancient aliens just happened to possess a perfect cure for McCoy's exact, incredibly rare 23rd-century terminal disease. 🔗
- **The Reset Button Climax:** McCoy is instantly cured, completely cheapening his tragic acceptance of death. He immediately leaves his new wife behind to go back to work on the *Enterprise*, completely resetting the status quo for the next week's episode. 📺 The View from the Junky... +2

The Third-Season Reality

By Season 3, NBC executives had slashed *Star Trek's* budget, moved it to a Friday night "death slot," and forced the production to rely heavily on recycled script formulas. Freelance writers were told to resolve complex sci-fi dilemmas quickly and cheaply using the standing ship sets. As a result,





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What was the original ending for For the World is Hollow and I Have Touched the Sky

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In the original pitch and story outlines for **"For the World is Hollow and I Have Touched the Sky"**, the episode was never meant to feature McCoy at all—**Chief Engineer Montgomery Scott (Scotty) was originally the one diagnosed with the terminal illness.** [Facebook](#) · Star Trek: Ori... +1





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final year using his engineering expertise to manually repair the spaceship's failing guidance systems. He would give his life to keep the population alive, creating a meaningful, bittersweet sacrifice. 🏠 Fandom +4

However, the producers decided that Dr. McCoy—who rarely got romantic lead storylines—was a better fit for the emotional weight of a tragic, terminal diagnosis. The script was completely rewritten to swap Scotty for McCoy. 🧑 the m0vie blog +2

2. The Abrupt Status Quo Mandate

Even after shifting the story to McCoy, the final act originally intended to dive deeper into the tragedy of his mortality. The ultimate resolution where a magical alien database has the exact, instant "miracle cure" for a rare 23rd-century disease was forced onto the script late in production. 🔗

Because *Star Trek* was an episodic syndication show in the 1960s, **studio executives heavily enforced a "status quo" rule**. No matter how world-altering or tragic an episode was, everything had to be perfectly reset by the 50-minute mark so local TV stations could air the episodes entirely out of order. The writers were barred from letting McCoy stay on the planet or suffer any long-term consequences, turning a complex story about accepting death into a rushed "miracle cure" exit. 🔗

Would you like to look at how **other crew members** like Scotty or Sulu were originally handled in early drafts, or are you interested in how **the "status quo" rule** ruined other major third-season *Star Trek* episodes?

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How did this effect the episode "The Apple"

14 July 2026

The exact same **studio status quo mandate**, mixed with sudden production adjustments, caused "**The Apple**" (Season 2, Episode 5) to completely abandon its terrifying opening stakes for a highly controversial and rushed ending. 🗨 Fandom +1

The episode follows a near-identical structural breakdown to "*The Return of the Archons*" and "*For the World is Hollow...*" due to executive formatting rules.

1. The Deadly Opening is Tossed Aside

The episode opens with the crew landing on the seemingly peaceful paradise planet Gamma Trianguli VI. The stakes are immediately raised to an extreme degree when the planet itself begins trying to violently murder the crew. 🗨 Fandom +2

In the first two acts, regular redshirts are brutally picked off one by one: one steps on an exploding rock, another is killed by a plant shooting poison thorns, and another is struck down by a sudden bolt of lightning.





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- **The Immediate Solution:** When Vaal uses a tractor beam to pull the *Enterprise* out of orbit, Kirk doesn't look for a peaceful compromise or scientific solution. Under time constraints, he simply orders the ship to fire its phasers directly at the underground machinery, starving Vaal of power and destroying it. [Facebook · Star Trek: Ori... +1](#)
- **The Contradictory Logic:** Kirk immediately justifies this massive violation of the Prime Directive by giving the peaceful, child-like primitive villagers a swift lecture. He tells them that being controlled by a machine isn't "real" living and that they are better off now. [Reddit · r/DaystromInstit... +2](#)

3. The Absurdly Lighthearted Wrap-Up

The most jarring effect of the studio's formatting rules happens on the bridge in the final scene. After an entire episode where multiple Starfleet crew members were brutally killed on screen by the planet, the episode relies on a standard comedy reset. [🔗](#)

Spock points out that by destroying their paradise and introducing the villagers to labor, marriage, and childbirth, Kirk has essentially acted as the biblical Satan by offering them the "forbidden apple" of knowledge. Kirk chuckles, looks at the camera, and jokes about whether Spock looks more like Satan than he does. The tragic losses and massive cultural destruction are completely swept away to ensure a happy, episodic ending. [🔗](#)

Are you interested in seeing the **original script differences** for "The Apple"—such as how **Sulu was originally supposed to be in the episode** instead of Chekov—or would you like to explore another episode where Kirk forced his morals onto a planet? [Facebook · Star Trek](#)

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